wickets and slipped to 146–5 in no time. I was out bowled trying to cut a ball from Ashley Giles. By now the mood in the dressing room had turned sombre and nobody was speaking – until Yuvraj Singh, the talented left-handed batsman, and Mohammad Kaif, a right-handed middle-order batsman and excellent fielder, started an unlikely recovery act. They were scoring boundaries freely and at no point did the asking rate go beyond manageable limits.

Once the partnership had started to blossom I had a feeling that something dramatic might happen. I can't explain why, but I was convinced it was not all over for us yet. The rest of the team sensed the opportunity too and soon each run was cheered in the dressing room. I was sitting on a table in the middle of the room and was eating one energy bar after another. I was not particularly hungry but in the intensity of the moment kept polishing off the bars. Before long the atmosphere had changed dramatically and everyone was engrossed in the game. Cricketers are a superstitious lot and no one was allowed to shift position. If someone wanted to go to the toilet, he wasn't allowed to do so in the middle of an over; he could only go at the end of an over and had to come back before the start of the next.

By the fortieth over, Yuvraj and Kaif had got the measure of the English bowling and we realized we had a real chance of winning the title. The next few batsmen were all charged up and even when Yuvraj got out for 69 there was no dip in intensity. Kaif was still out there and we knew that the target was within reach. Finally, when Zaheer and Kaif ran the winning runs in the last over of the match, the dressing room leaped in delight. We could not stop smiling and hugging each other – and Sourav did the unthinkable of taking off his shirt and waving it above his head as he stood bare-chested on the Lord's balcony. It is an iconic image now but for some reason Sourav is always much too embarrassed to talk about it whenever I ask him!

We stayed in the dressing room for hours, picking over the finer points of the victory. We'd heard that the England team had ordered champagne by the middle of our innings and had put a number of bottles on ice. With India at 146–5, an English win was deemed a mere formality. I don't know if this story is true, but a number of our players suggested to the England team at the end of the game that it was time to pass the champagne over to us. We would be happy to take care of it. A number